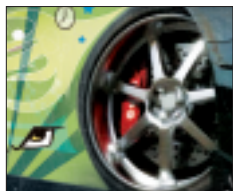




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Lead Feature

The Stingy Gamer

...or, how I learned to stop spending and love my old rig



Nimish Chandiramani

We've got a Core 2 Duo rig with an NVIDIA 8800 Ultra and 4 GB of RAM for our game reviews, and we're quite happy with the situation. Then comes *Crysis*, which knocks the wind out of it with everything set to Very High. Suddenly, our world is plunged into darkness—we didn't spend all that time harassing the Powers That Be for a gaming rig only to find out that we'll have to settle for... ugh... lower settings. Do we go SLI? How do we explain the dunking of another Rs 30,000 (or thereabouts) to the Führ... er... boss?

That's beside the point, actually. While our professional lives are brightened by the ray of sunshine that is the corporate budget, most of us game at home on fairly modest machines—a mid-range AMD64 (Socket 939 at that), an 8600 GT and 2 GB of RAM. Yes, we are content, and yes, we still call ourselves gamers. Our secret? Nothing complicated, just the realisation of a few simple truths...

The Early Adopter's Caveat

This happens to us too often to laugh about—on day 1, we go out to our local electronics hub and blow a good portion of our salaries on an upgrade, and on day 3, prices plummet and we feel like complete asses. You don't realise it, but we can see you nodding your head.

Now consider the plight of someone who sprung for an NVIDIA 8800GTX back when it was Rs 40,000—the newly-released 8800GT is only slightly behind it in performance, but costs half that much. If you spend the same amount today, you can use two 8800GTs in SLI and elicit a performance that surpasses even the 8800Ultra! The situation is the same in the ATI camp.

Our point is this: early adopters adopt early mostly because they can, not because they need to—they are fully aware of the fact that prices are going to fall soon; they just don't care. With graphics cards today, jumping the gun comes at a price, so hang tight and buy a new card only when there's nothing you can do to improve your gaming experience, or till your old card goes poof.

Until then...

Ugly Is Beautiful

The most obvious—don't lose heart if you have to play games at lower settings on your current PC. A good case in point is *Crysis* itself—even